



A: First of all, you must remember that ESG is relatively new and people have been talking about it in the last five years or so. But does that mean that before that we were avoiding environment, social or governance factors? They were always there; they were risk factors. So, we always had to pay attention. But then it has become more formalised and many of our clients insisted that we look at environment, and global warming and the rest of the factors and India of course had to follow. And, it was not just India, even China and all other markets had to follow. Many people would say that India is still far behind but I would say that India is right up there with everybody else. Simply because investors were insisting. So, when I talk to an Indian company, I find them very aware of ESG and also sustainability. India has done a pretty good job because the thing with India is that there is a lot of transparency. So, it is easy to get answers.

Q: So, would it be right to say that the investment universe of Indian companies compliant with ESG benchmarks has expanded over the years, especially in the context of global investors looking to put money in India?

A: Yes, it has increased dramatically because of the demand from investors. We invest in small- and medium-sized companies and they are also very aware of these factors and they are willing to work with us to improve that.

Q: You have been an advocate of women directors on the boards of companies. What are the advantages you see if there is a woman on the board of directors of a company?

A: I really think that women directors are very important to a company to get a different view. And also, diversity in general with people from different social backgrounds or different income levels or workers. A good company needs to get different views. It is very critical and it should not be just window dressing but people who can really contribute and the company should be open to such ideas. We always like to see women on the boards as women can give the company a different view or a different aspect... I don't care what the sector is, it is good to have a woman on the board. More than that, maybe the chairperson as a woman. **BT**

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